

UTT Chapter 10 Assignment

Hey there!

I am so happy it is Christmas break. Finally I can have a few weeks to relax before the next semester starts. Finals went well thanks to all those hours in the library. I can't believe how much I studied this semester! I don't think I have ever studied so much in my life. Paige was a lifesaver on that Art History paper. Anyway, I am going to spend this holiday sleeping (a lot!) and of course hanging out with you and the rest of my old friends. I think I might also try to pick up a few games of soccer with my little brother. He just joined the middle school team. It will be fun to show him the ropes while I am at home. Hopefully I haven't lost my game since intramurals!

I had an interesting conversation with Muhammad and Nathan before school ended. While we were working out at the gym, a news special on academic dishonesty was playing on the televisions. Apparently a group of seniors at some university up north were expelled due to a huge cheating scandal. That, of course, started us talking about cheating and dishonesty, which eventually led us to the topic of ethics. Nathan shook his head and muttered something about karma. Naturally, I had heard of karma before, but I wasn't quite sure what he meant. He went on to say that the consequences of what we do for good or bad will eventually be returned back to us. This sounds very similar to Christianity, since I think I remember the Bible saying something about how your sins will eventually find you out. Of course, I doubt it is that simple.

This started me thinking about what Sarah and Mark might say. I know they don't believe in God or the Bible, so what do they base their ethical views on? Also, are they different? **What is the Secularist's basis for ethics?** And **what is the Marxist's basis for ethics?** I can imagine Paige, as a Postmodernist, would say that all truth is constructed and that we make our own truth, but what does that mean for ethics? **What do Postmodernists think about ethics?** To some degree, I understand Nathan's position, but **what is the basis of ethics for New Spiritualists?** Muhammad spoke up and said that it isn't karma that ultimately judges our actions. It is Allah. If we continually break Allah's law and act contrary to the example set by the prophet, then we will be eternally punished. I know that Islam calls God "Allah," but I am not sure what the prophet Muhammad had to do with right and wrong. And Christians believe that God gave us laws to obey. **What is the difference between the Islamic and Christian understanding of ethics?**

Thanks a lot for helping me out with all my questions! Good thing I have such an intelligent friend like you!

Talk to you later,
-Doug

Doug brought up five different questions; below is a rough outline of possible responses:

1. What is the Secularist's basis for ethics?

Secularism's ethic begins with three basic assumptions: (a) God doesn't exist (b) the material world is all that there is, and (c) knowledge only comes through science. Since there isn't an unchanging standard on which to ground morality (e.g. God or transcendent ideals), it is up to human beings to define right and wrong. Given Secularism's foundation, it tends toward **moral relativism**—the idea that morality is relative to the individual or culture. This is a position that some Secularists readily accept, but others try to avoid. Unable to ground morality in anything transcendent, other Secularists turn to teleological ethical theories, usually utilitarianism. Instead of basing morality upon unchanging principals, **utilitarianism** asserts that we ought to do whatever maximizes happiness and reduces suffering for the greatest number of people. [10.3]

2. What is the Marxist's basis for ethics?

Marxism essentially begins with the same basic assumptions as Secularism (i.e. atheism, materialism, and scientism). However, unlike Secularism, Marxism believes society is inevitably moving toward the elimination of all social and economic distinctions. Therefore, Marxists agree that ethics should be teleological but with communism as the ultimate ethical ideal. According to Marxism, right and wrong aren't determined by actions themselves. **Proletariat morality** is the belief that anything that advances the cause of the proletariat is moral, and anything that impedes the progress of the proletariat is immoral. [10.4]

3. How do Postmodernists think about ethics?

Postmodernism rejects any ethical system built upon revelation, reason, or science. According to Postmodernism, moral absolutes simply don't exist as either ethical means or ends. Instead Postmodernists advocate living within "little narratives" in the form of **cultural relativism**—the belief that truth and morals are relative to one's culture. Right and wrong aren't concrete facts. Instead, one's community determines right and wrong. Every culture has its own set of moral standards that evolved over time according to the needs and consensus of that society. [10.6]

4. What is the basis of ethics for New Spiritualists?

Many New Spiritualists believe that the only ethical absolute is complete freedom to act in harmony with our own understanding of truth. According to this view, moral truth is not found in doctrines, ideologies, societal expectations, or divine commands. Rather, truth is something we find within

ourselves. Because New Spiritualism is based on the belief that we are divine, simply connecting with our own divinity makes each of us the sole arbiter of right and wrong. Following any external limits would only inhibit our divinity and delay our spiritual progression.

This American individualistic context of New Spiritualism asserts autonomy as the only ethical imperative. However, some New Spiritualists recognize certain behaviors as objectively immoral. Both Buddhism and Hinduism identify particular acts as either objectively moral or immoral. In fact, the principal of **karma**—the belief that good is returned to those who do good and evil is returned to those who do evil—offers a degree of ethical accountability to many New Spiritualists. Thus, generally speaking, New Spiritualists try to refrain from causing harm to others and consequently bringing about future suffering to themselves. [10.5]

5. What is the difference between the Islamic and Christian understanding of ethics?

Muslims derive their ethics from the Quran and the Hadith, following what is known as **Divine Command Theory**—the belief that right and wrong are determined by God’s commands. The Hadith provides an example of what Islam considers exemplary living through the life of the prophet Muhammad. Since the Quran presents God as directly unknowable, Muslims follow Allah’s decrees through Muhammad’s example. Muslims aren’t motivated to act ethically because of their relationship to God. Muslims desire to develop virtues in anticipation for the coming day of judgment.

Christianity, on the hand, teaches that no one can attain salvation through his or her own works. It is only by God’s grace through the blood of Christ that anyone can stand before God. Christianity recognizes a personal and relational God, who has revealed himself to us through his Scriptures. Right and wrong flow out of God’s character, not his decrees. Morality is written into his nature and inscribed upon our hearts. Ethics is an extension of God’s nature. He is not merely a divine rule-maker; rather, he is a Savior. **Agape** is the belief that morality is built upon two foundational moral absolutes: love God and love neighbor. [10.7–10.8]